GUJARATI COLLECTION

NO. 06



GUJARAT ORIGIN

Tuvar Lilva Shaak

Fresh Pigeon Pea Curry
A Fleeting Winter Delicacy

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Tuvar Lilva Shaak

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Vegetable That Waits for Winter

Tuvar lilva — fresh, green pigeon peas, shelled straight from their pods — occupy a special place in Gujarati cooking precisely because of their scarcity: unlike the dried toor dal available year-round, fresh tuvar lilva appears in markets for only a few weeks each winter, when the pigeon pea plants are harvested young before the peas fully mature and dry. That narrow window transforms an otherwise everyday legume into something genuinely anticipated each year.

When fresh lilva does arrive, Gujarati households make the most of it, using it not only in this standalone shaak but also as one of the defining ingredients in undhiyu, the elaborate winter vegetable medley featured elsewhere in this collection. Cooked simply with a light, spiced gravy, tuvar lilva shaak lets the pea's fresh, slightly sweet flavor take center stage rather than burying it under heavy spicing.

For Gujaratis living outside the region or those without easy access to fresh lilva, frozen versions — imported or prepared during the season and frozen for later use — offer a practical way to enjoy the dish beyond its brief natural season, though many will tell you nothing quite matches the first fresh batch of the winter.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Vegetable That Waits for Winter, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Available fresh for only a few weeks each winter, making this dish a genuinely anticipated seasonal treat in Gujarati households. One of the defining ingredients in undhiyu, Gujarat's elaborate winter vegetable medley, alongside its role as a standalone dish. Reflects a broader pattern in Gujarati cooking of celebrating specific seasonal ingredients during their brief window of peak availability. A dish that showcases the pea's fresh, delicate flavor rather than masking it with heavy spicing.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	20m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Tuvar lilva shaak keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. It freezes reasonably well for up to 2 months, making it worthwhile to prepare extra during the short lilva season for enjoying later in the year.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Fresh tuvar lilva (pigeon peas), shelled, or frozen	2 cups	250 g	2 katori
Oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Green chili, slit	2	2	2
Ginger paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Water	½ cup	120 ml	½ katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fresh tuvar lilva is genuinely difficult to find outside India and outside its brief winter season; frozen tuvar lilva, sold at some South Asian grocers, is the best substitute and captures much of the fresh flavor. If neither is available, fresh or frozen green peas (matar) can be used as a completely different but still tasty alternative, understanding the dish will taste noticeably different from the traditional version.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Tuvar Lilva Shaak

01 TEMPER THE SPICES

Heat oil in a kadai and add mustard seeds, letting them pop. Add cumin seeds and asafoetida, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.

02 ADD CHILI AND GINGER

Add the slit green chilies and ginger paste, cooking briefly until fragrant.

03 ADD THE LILVA AND SPICES

Add the tuvar lilva, turmeric, and coriander powder, stirring to coat evenly.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Tuvar Lilva Shaak, continued



04 COOK COVERED

Add the water, sugar, and salt. Cover and cook on medium-low heat for 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the lilva is tender.

Texture indicator. properly cooked tuvar lilva should be tender but still hold its shape, with a slightly creamy bite rather than mushy.

05 FINISH WITH LEMON

Stir in the lemon juice and fresh coriander just before serving, for a bright finishing note.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Tuvar Lilva Shaak, continued



MISTAKE TO AVOID

Overcooking fresh tuvar lilva turns it mushy and loses its pleasant, slightly firm texture — check for doneness starting around the 10-minute mark rather than assuming it needs the full cooking time.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of a winter Gujarati thali alongside rice, roti, and dal.
- A seasonal treat eagerly anticipated each year when fresh lilva first appears in markets.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A simple, comforting winter side dish, often made in larger batches to freeze for later enjoyment.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a light, protein-rich side dish alongside any grain or bread.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Timing Right

- Fresh lilva cooks relatively quickly — start checking for doneness earlier than you might expect to avoid overcooking.
- A light hand with spicing lets the pea's natural sweetness shine through, rather than masking it.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Consider making a larger batch during lilva season and freezing portions to enjoy the flavor throughout the year.
- This dish is quick enough that extensive advance preparation usually isn't necessary during its fresh season.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small amount of grated coconut at the end for extra richness, particularly when making a more festive version of this otherwise simple dish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

150 kcal	7 g	18 g	6 g	6 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Tuvar Lilva with Coconut	an enriched version with grated coconut stirred in at the end.
Tuvar Lilva Muthiya Nu Shaak	combined with muthiya dumplings for a heartier dish.
Undhiyu-Style Lilva	the same peas used as part of the larger undhiyu vegetable medley in this collection.

Can I use dried toor dal instead?

No — this dish specifically uses fresh, green pigeon peas, which have a different texture and flavor from dried toor dal and cook much more quickly.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Where can I find frozen tuvar lilva?

Some South Asian grocers stock it frozen, particularly those catering to a Gujarati clientele — worth calling ahead to check availability.

Is this dish very spicy?

No — it's mild, letting the fresh pea flavor come through, with just gentle warmth from the green chili.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Lilva	Gujarati for fresh, green pigeon peas, harvested young before drying.
Toor Dal	the dried, split version of the same pigeon pea, available year-round.
Shaak	Gujarati for a vegetable curry or side dish.
Undhiyu	Gujarat's elaborate winter vegetable medley, which also features fresh tuvar lilva.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Tuvar Lilva Shaak

10m	20m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Fresh tuvar lilva	250 g
Oil	45 ml
Mustard seeds	4 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Asafoetida	pinch
Green chili	2
Ginger paste	15 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Sugar	4 g
Water	120 ml
Salt	6 g
Fresh coriander	8 g
Lemon juice	15 ml

METHOD

01 **Temper the spices.** Heat oil in a kadai and add mustard seeds, letting them pop.

02 **Add chili and ginger.** Add the slit green chilies and ginger paste, cooking briefly until fragrant.

03 **Add the lilva and spices.** Add the tuvar lilva, turmeric, and coriander powder, stirring to coat evenly.

04 **Cook covered.** Add the water, sugar, and salt.

05 **Finish with lemon.** Stir in the lemon juice and fresh coriander just before serving, for a bright finishing note.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Fresh tuvar lilva	250 g	☐ Oil	45 ml
☐ Mustard seeds	4 g	☐ Cumin seeds	4 g
☐ Asafoetida	pinch	☐ Green chili	2
☐ Ginger paste	15 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Sugar	4 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g
☐ Lemon juice	15 ml		

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